Chapter Twenty-Seven

The Mongol School of Warfare

Between 1201 and 1215, Genghis Khan learns how to fight the civilized world

SINCE 1165, the Jin in the north of China and the Song in the south had kept a fragile peace. But now, a first whisper of unease came from the lands to the north.

Ranging across the flat northern grasslands known as steppes were a loosely related set of tribes known collectively as "Mongols." They had already migrated southward from the *taiga*, the cold northern pine forests; according to their own chronicles, the thirteenth-century *The Secret History of the Mongols*, they had descended from the union of a forest doe with a predatory blue-grey wolf. Every Mongol tribe had its own *khan* to lead it, and the khans and tribes struggled with each other for power. But within each tribe, clans and their chiefs fought constantly among themselves for horses, wives, loot, and the chance to rise to leadership of the tribe.[1]

Temujin, son of the chief of the Borjigid clan, was born near the sacred mountain of Burkhan Khaldun in 1167; *The Secret History* says that the newborn was "clutching in his right hand a clot of blood the size of a knucklebone." At the age of nine, he was betrothed to the ten-year-old daughter of a clan leader from another tribe, and was sent (as was traditional) to live with the bride's family. Days later, his father died, and Temujin ran away from his prospective father-in-law and returned home.[2]

This was the beginning of a fraught adolescence. Temujin and his family